QP 25900370

Mahatma Gandhi University, Kottayam
MGU-UGP (Honours) Regular Examination October 2025
Third Semester
Discipline Specific Core Course (DSC) - MG3DSCENG200 –
An Introduction to Phonetics

Duration: 2 Hours **Maximum Marks: 70**

Scheme of Valuation

Part A

MCQ

Answer all questions. Each question carries 1 marks

1. a) The vibration of vocal cords [CO1]
2. c) /u:/ [CO2]
3. a) /f/ and /v/ [CO3]
4. c) Content words [CO4]
5. b) Middle English [CO1]
6. a) Question lacks clarity – marks may be awarded. [CO2]
7. c) Epenthesis [CO3]
8. a) Secondary phonemes [CO4]
9. c) /kʌbəd/ [CO2]
10. a) /s/ [CO3]

[1x10 = 10]

Part B

SHORT ANSWER

Answer any 6 questions. Each question carries 5 marks

11. **Phonetics** – studies physical properties of speech sounds – articulation, transmission and perception – concerns sound form. **Phonology** - analyses how sounds are organised – function within a language – focus on patterns and rules – role of sounds in communication. [CO1]
12. No one-to-one correspondence between letters and sounds – English spelling is not a reliable guide to pronunciation – challenging to learners. Eg: Pacific Ocean – letter 'c' pronounced as /s/ in Pacific, /k/ in Pacific and /ʃ/ in Ocean. [CO2]
13. **Releasing consonants** - occur at the beginning of syllables – movement from a consonantal closure toward a more open articulation for the following vowel – release into the nucleus of the syllable – involve an outward motion of airflow – pronounced with greater clarity and force. Eg. /b/ in *bat*. **Arresting consonants** - occur at the end of syllables – movement from open vowel position to a consonantal closure – arrest or close off the syllable – involve reduced or incomplete articulation – may be subject to neutralisation or weakening processes. Eg. /t/ of *bat*. [CO3]
14. **Assimilation** – a sound changes because of the sound that comes before or after it – makes speech flow smoothly – mostly affects consonants. Can be Phonemic or Allophonic. **Phonemic** – one sound is replaced by a completely different one, changing the identity of the phoneme. Eg clean boots /kli:n bu:ts/ becomes /kli:m bu:ts/ - /n/ becomes /m/ before the bilabial /b/ in /bu:ts/. **Allophonic** – basic sound remains the same – pronunciation shifts slightly. Eg. /hæz tu:/ becomes /hæs tu:/ - /z/ becomes /s/ due to the influence of the voiceless /t/ [CO4]

15. **Protolanguage** – a common ancestral language from which related languages descend. Comparative reconstruction - used by linguists to identify and reconstruct proto languages – involves examining consistent patterns of vocabulary, grammar and phonology across various languages – linguists gain ideas about the phonological, morphological and lexical features of ancestral languages in the absence of written records. [CO1].
16. **Cardinal Vowel System** - developed by Daniel Jones – standard reference framework of vowels – can be used to describe all possible vowel sounds in human speech – represent extreme or fixed positions of the tongue and lips in the vowel area – not necessarily found in any particular language. [CO2].
17. **Morphologically conditioned allomorphs** - variations of a morpheme that appear due to grammatical or morphological reasons rather than phonetic context – choice of allomorph does not follow phonological patterns but depends on the specific word it attaches to. Example, the plural morpheme appears as *-en* in *oxen* and *-ren* in *children*. [CO3]
18. Devotee: //ˈhaʊ dɪˈvaɪn ðiˈætməsfɪəˈfiːlzˎ //
    //ɪz ðəˈpuːdʒəˈəʊvəˀ//
    //ˈwɒtˈtaɪm ɪz ˌdiːpɑːˈrɑːdənəˀ//
    Priest: //ɪt wɪlˈstɑːtətˈsɪks ɪn ðiˈiːvnɪŋˎ //
    Devotee: //kən wiːˈgetˈprəsɑːdəmˈhɪəˀ// [CO4]
    Note: ***Transcription of Malayalam words need not be considered for awarding marks.***
19. **Tone group** - unit of speech – every tone group has a main word that stands out owing to the presence of the nuclear or tonic syllable - parts of a tone group - the pre-head (unstressed syllables before the first stressed one), the head (from the first stressed syllable to the nucleus), the nucleus (the syllable carrying the main pitch change), and the tail (syllables following the nucleus). [CO4]

[5x6 = 30]

Part C

ESSAY

Answer any 2 questions. Each question carries 15 marks

20. Speech – complex activity involving multiple systems of the human body. The **respiratory system**– provides the necessary airflow – comprises lungs, diaphragm, intercostals muscles and trachea. The **phonatory system** includes the larynx and the vocal cords – modifies the airstream by the vibration of the vocal folds. The **articulatory system** – comprises nose, tongue, lips, teeth, and roof of the mouth - shapes airstream distinct speech sounds like vowels and consonants. These systems work together to transform breath into meaningful spoken language. [CO1]

21. **Diphthong** – a combination of two vowels in a single syllable – tongue glides from one vowel position to another – called vowel glides – eight diphthongs in English RP. **Falling Diphthongs** – First element is more prominent than the second (/eɪ/ ,/aɪ/ , /ɔɪ/,/aʊ/) - **Rising Diphthongs** – Second element is more prominent than the first – not common in English RP. **Closing diphthongs** – tongue glides towards a close vowel, /eɪ/ (*say*), /aɪ/ (*my*), /ɔɪ/ (*boy*), /əʊ/ (*go*), /aʊ/ (*now*). Centring diphthongs - tongue glides towards a central vowel, /ɪə/ (*near*), /eə/ (*care*), /ʊə/ (*poor*). **Fronting Diphthongs** – tongue moves towards a front vowel (/eɪ/ ,/aɪ/ , /ɔɪ/ /ɪə/ /eə/. **Retracting Diphthongs** – tongue glides towards a back or central vowel (/əʊ/, /aʊ/) [CO2]

21. Allophones – context-based variations of the same phoneme - do not change the meaning of a word – written within square brackets to indicate their actual pronunciation in specific situations. Eg. /p/ is aspirated [pʰ] in *pin* (stressed syllable) but unaspirated [p] in *spin* (unstressed syllable). The phoneme /l/ is clear [l] in *leaf* (when it is followed by a vowel) and dark [ɫ] in *ball* (word final/ not followed by a vowel). Key characteristics – phonetically similar, Complementary distribution, Free Variation. [CO3]

22. Arun : //ˈhaʊ ə juː ˈfiːlɪŋ ˈbiːdʒuːˀ//
Biju : //aɪm əˈfreɪd ɪt ˈɪznt ˈgʊd njuːzˋ//
Arun: //əʊ nəʊ | ˈwɒt ˈhæpəndˀ//
Biju: //ðə ˈdɒktə ˈseɪz ðeəz ə sɪˈvɪər ɪnˈfekʃən ɪn maɪ ɪnˈtestɪnzˋ//
//ðeɪ meɪ ˈiːvən hæv tə ˈɒpəreɪtˋ//
//ði ˈæntɪbaɪɒtɪks ən ðə ˈləʊnlɪnəs ə ˈrɪəli ˈweərɪŋ mi daʊnˋ//
Arun: //dəʊnt ˈwʌri | aɪm ˈhɪə fə juːˋ//
//ˈwɒt əˈbaʊt jɔːˈfæməliˀ//
Biju: //ðeɪ ˈkʌm | bət nɒt ˈɒfnˋ//
//maɪ ˈfɑːðə ɪz ˈtaɪd ʌp wɪð ˈwɜːk frəm ˈmɔːnɪŋ tɪl ˈnaɪtˋ//
//ˈʌmə drɒps ɪn ˈregjələli | bət ʃiː kɑːnt steɪ fə lɒŋˋ //
Arun: //ənd jɔː ˈʌðə frendzˀ//
Biju: //jes | ə fjuː ˈvɪzɪt | bət ðeɪ ˈɔːlsəʊ dəʊnt steɪ lɒŋˋ//
//ət taɪmz aɪ ˈfiːl səʊ ˈləʊnli | əˈfreɪd ənd dɪˈprestˋ //
Arun: //ðæts ˈnætʃrəl | bət dəʊnt ˈluːz hɑːtˋ//
//aɪ hæv θriː kənˈsekjətɪv ˈhɒlədeɪz ˈkʌmɪŋ ʌpˋ//
//aɪl biː ˈhɪə ˈevrɪ deɪ wɪð ə frend əv maɪnˋ//
//ðə θriː əv ʌs kən spend lɒŋ ˈaʊəz təˈgeðəˋ | ˈʧætɪŋ | ˈpleɪɪŋ kɑːdz | ən ˈlɪsənɪŋ tə ˈmjuːzɪkˋ//
//aɪl ˈɔːlsəʊ brɪŋ maɪ ˈaɪpɒd | səʊ wenəvə juːˈfiːl bɔːd juː kən ˈlɪsənˋ//
//juːv ˈɔːlweɪz lʌvd ˈmjuːzɪk | hævnt juːˀ//
Biju: //jes | ðæt wəd ˈrɪəli ˈʧɪə mi ʌpˋ //
Arun: //ˈdɒktə | meɪ aɪ nəʊ haʊ lɒŋ ˈbiːdʒuː wɪl niːd tə steɪ hɪəˀ//
//aɪ həʊp ɪt ˈɪznt təˈsɪərɪəsˀ//
Doctor: //ɪts ən ɪnˈtestɪnəl ˈprɒbləmˋ//
//wɪə ˈrʌnɪŋ testsˋ//
//hiː wɪl rɪˈkʌvə | dəʊnt ˈwʌriˋ//
Arun: //bət haʊ lɒŋ wɪl ɪt teɪk ˈdɒktəˀ//
Doctor: //wiː kɑːnt seɪ fə ʃʊə | ʌnˈtɪl ðə rɪˈpɔːts kʌmˋ//
Arun: //ˈθæŋk juː ˈdɒktə | pliːz teɪk ˈgʊd keə əv maɪ frendˋ//
// dəʊnt ˈwʌri jɑːˋ//
//aɪ spəʊk tə ðə ˈdɒktə | hiː sed ɪts ˈnʌθɪŋ ˈveri ˈsɪərɪəsˋ//
//naʊ ˈʧɪər ʌp | lets ˈpleɪ səm kɑːdzˋ//

[CO4]

Note: Flexibility may be allowed for standard dialectal variations. Award marks for close attempts. May adopt the following criteria: Accuracy of 90% and above – 15 marks, 80% to 89% - 12 to 14 marks, 75% to 79% – 10 to 11 marks, 50% to 74% - 8 to 9 marks, 30% to 49% - 5 to 7 marks, Below 30% - 1 to 4 marks.

[2 x 15 = 30]